

GIACOMO MANFERDINI

Bocconi University, Department of Economics

Website | giacomo.manferdini@phd.unibocconi.it | +39 3387488419

EDUCATION

PhD in Economics <i>Bocconi University</i>	2021–present
MSc in Economics <i>University of Bologna, 110/110 cum laude</i>	2018–2020
BSc in Economics and Finance <i>University of Bologna, 110/110 cum laude</i>	2015–2018

FIELDS

Political Economy, Behavioral Economics

JOB MARKET PAPER

“Blameocracy: Causal Rhetoric in Politics” (with Francesco Bilotta and Alberto Binetti)

Democratic politics requires voters to infer how political actions map into outcomes, yet these causal links are often unclear, giving politicians scope to shape voters’ causal accounts. This paper studies the supply and returns of causal rhetoric in politics: politicians’ language linking political actions to outcomes through blame and credit. We fine-tune a language model to measure its use in 4.2 million congressional tweets spanning 2012–2023. Causal rhetoric is central to politicians’ communication: it accounts for more than one third of tweets, is the language of political disagreement, and rises over time. The political returns of causal rhetoric are concentrated in blame. Combining campaign contributions with quasi-exogenous geographic variation in Twitter adoption, we find that exposure to blame has the largest effects on small donations. Using voting intentions from survey data and an event-study design around blame-only and credit-only days, we find that politicians’ support rises after blame-only days. Additional evidence suggests that causal rhetoric, especially blame, may slant the causal accounts voters receive by turning complex economic mechanisms into underqualified but plausible, politically convenient claims.

PUBLICATIONS

“Coarse Memory and Plausible Narratives” (with Francesco Bilotta) *Forthcoming AEJ: Microeconomics*

We develop a dynamic model of narrative-based political competition. Voters recall the frequency of policies and outcomes, but not how they are correlated. Politicians exploit such coarse memory by crafting plausible narratives that overstate their policy’s effectiveness, reattributing outcomes to steal credit and shift blame. Because plausibility makes narrative optimism fall with policy implementation, incumbency erodes narrative advantage. This force generates endogenous policy cycles and, in the long run, makes tenure independent of true policy effectiveness. Extensions of the baseline model show how its mechanisms extend to analogy-based expectations, preferences for truth-telling, and heterogeneous voter feedback.

WORKING PAPERS

“Persuading with Memory”

This paper studies persuasion through memory. I use a theory-driven experiment in which an advisor and an investor share a common history of past news, but the advisor’s only action is to re-report one previously observed

item when the investor forms his belief. The experiment randomly varies both advisors' incentives and the association between contexts and signals across realized histories. Re-reporting past information creates scope for persuasion: investors' beliefs move with advisors' incentives, and advisors strategically choose which item to re-report. In this nuanced strategic setting, however, the data do not support the specific associative-memory mechanism emphasized by the framework. The findings identify memory as a distinct margin of persuasion while leaving open which features of memory drive persuasion in strategic environments.

"Policy Implementation and Congressional Rhetoric: Evidence from the Affordable Care Act" (with Francesco Bilotta)

How does policy implementation change the rhetoric elected officials use to connect policy to economic outcomes? We study Medicaid expansion under the Affordable Care Act, whose staggered state rollout changed the local policy environment facing members of the U.S. House. Linking implementation timing to 1.6 million tweets from 2012 to 2019, we measure insurance premium mentions and cross-party semantic similarity in ACA rhetoric within states. Before implementation, both parties linked the ACA to premiums, but with opposite valence. During implementation, however, supporters moved away from that link: Democrats reduced ACA-premium co-mentions by about 3.5 percentage points over two years, while Republicans did not; moreover, cross-party semantic similarity rose by about one-half of a standard deviation. These shifts occur even though the ACA is associated with lower premium growth in expansion states. The evidence suggests that implementation can narrow supporters' rhetorical possibilities even when a policy is associated with its intended outcomes.

WORK IN PROGRESS

"Information Campaigns, Peer Interactions, and Beliefs about Carbon Taxes" (with Stefano Carattini, Pamela Giustinelli, and Marcella Veronesi) *Data collection in progress ([pre-analysis plan](#))*

Biased, overly pessimistic beliefs represent an important obstacle to the adoption of cost-effective policy instruments, such as carbon taxes. With a large survey experiment, we investigate the effectiveness, on impact and over time, of information provision about the functioning of carbon taxes. We aim to simulate the potential of an actual information campaign, including interactions among peers about the content of the campaign. Such information campaigns are widely used in European countries. We focus on one of the few such countries without its own domestic carbon pricing scheme, Italy.

PRESENTATIONS

2026: Applied Young Economist Webinar; XXIII RIDGE Political Economy Workshop; 9th Economics of Media Bias Workshop; 12th Bounded Rationality in Choice Conference; AI and Society Conference; Cognitive Economics Workshop.

2025: 2nd Verona Early Career Workshop in Economics; Lancaster Workshop on Text-as-Data in Economics; Potsdam Text-as-Data in Behavioral Economics Workshop; XIV IBEO Political Economy Workshop; 1st Berlin Micro Theory and Behavioral Economics PhD Conference; 10th Monash-Paris-Warwick-Zurich-CEPR Text-As-Data Workshop; 1st Annual Interdisciplinary WZB-CEPR Conference; 18th UniTo-CCA PhD Workshop in Economics; 3rd Political Economy Winter Workshop.

2024: XVIII GRASS Workshop Turin; 2nd Political Economy Winter Workshop.

2023: Beliefs, Narratives, and Memory Workshop; 1st Political Economy Winter Workshop.

REFEREEING

European Journal of Political Economy; Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

RA for Prof. Salvatore Nunnari, Bocconi University

2026

RA for Prof. Pamela Giustinelli, <i>Bocconi University</i>	2023–2025
RA for Prof. Lorenz Goette and Prof. Egon Tripodi, <i>University of Bonn</i>	2020–2021
RA for Prof. Maria Bigoni, <i>University of Bologna</i>	2019–2020

TEACHING

TA Econometrics (Master), <i>Bocconi University</i>	2023–present
TA Game Theory (Master), <i>Bocconi University</i>	2023–present
TA Microeconomics and Macroeconomics (Bachelor), <i>Bocconi University</i>	2022–present

SCHOLARSHIPS AND AWARDS

Behavioral Finance e.V. research , EUR 5,000 (PI)	2025
PhD Fellowship, <i>IGIER Bocconi University</i>	2026–2027
PhD Fellowship, <i>Fondazione Romeo ed Enrica Invernizzi</i>	2025–2027
PhD Fellowship, <i>Bocconi University</i>	2021–2025
Prize for Deserving Students, <i>University of Bologna</i>	2020
Merit-Based Fees Exemption for Deserving Students, <i>University of Bologna</i>	2018

REFERENCES

Prof. Massimo Morelli
Bocconi University
massimo.morelli@unibocconi.it

Prof. Nicola Gennaioli
Bocconi University
nicola.gennaioli@unibocconi.it

Prof. Egon Tripodi
Hertie School
tripodi@hertie-school.org

Prof. Carlo Schwarz
Bocconi University
carlo.schwarz@unibocconi.it